

# **Pornography Consumption, Self-Control, and Daily Productivity Among Young Adults: A Cross-Sectional Mediation and Developmental Analysis.**

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## What This Study Asked

Does pornography consumption affect productivity and if so, how? This study examined four questions:

1. Is pornography consumption associated with productivity?
2. Does self-control explain this relationship?
3. Does the age of first pornography exposure influence current porn consumption patterns, self-control, and productivity?
4. Do these patterns differ between men and women?

## How the Study Was Conducted

A group of 250 adults (aged 18+) from diverse cultural backgrounds participated in an anonymous online questionnaire shared across various digital channels. Participants reported their pornography consumption frequency, self-control, productivity, age of first exposure, and demographic characteristics. Statistical analyses included correlation, bootstrapped mediation analysis (5000 resamples), and group comparisons, with a significance level of 0.05.

## What Was Found

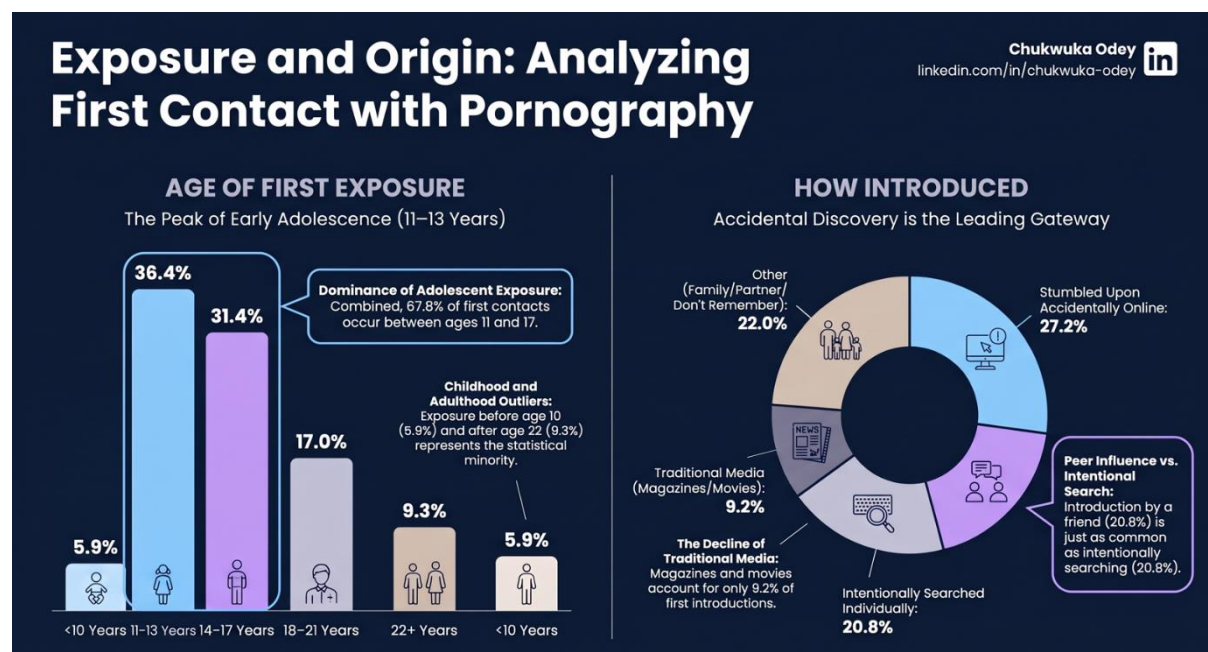


Figure 1. Early Exposure Profiles: Age at First Contact and Initial Exposure Pathways

A visual summary showing respondents' age at first exposure and the primary social or digital channels through which they were introduced.

### 1. Pornography consumption is linked to lower productivity.

A statistically significant negative correlation was found between pornography consumption and productivity ( $r_s = -0.157$ ,  $p = 0.013$ ). Higher consumption was associated with slightly lower productivity. However, the effect is small indicating that pornography is one of many factors influencing productivity.

### 2. Self-control explains the link.

The mediation analysis showed that pornography consumption does not directly lower productivity. Instead, it reduces self-control, and this reduced self-control is what lowers productivity. Path A (porn  $\rightarrow$  self-control) was significant ( $\beta = -0.145$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ), and Path B (self-control  $\rightarrow$  productivity) was also significant ( $\beta = 1.297$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ). When self-control was accounted for, the direct effect of pornography on productivity disappeared entirely (direct effect  $\beta = 0.032$ ,  $p = 0.681$ , n.s. (not significant)), while the indirect effect through self-control was significant ( $\beta = -0.188$ , 95% CI  $[-0.287, -0.098]$ ). This forms a full mediation.

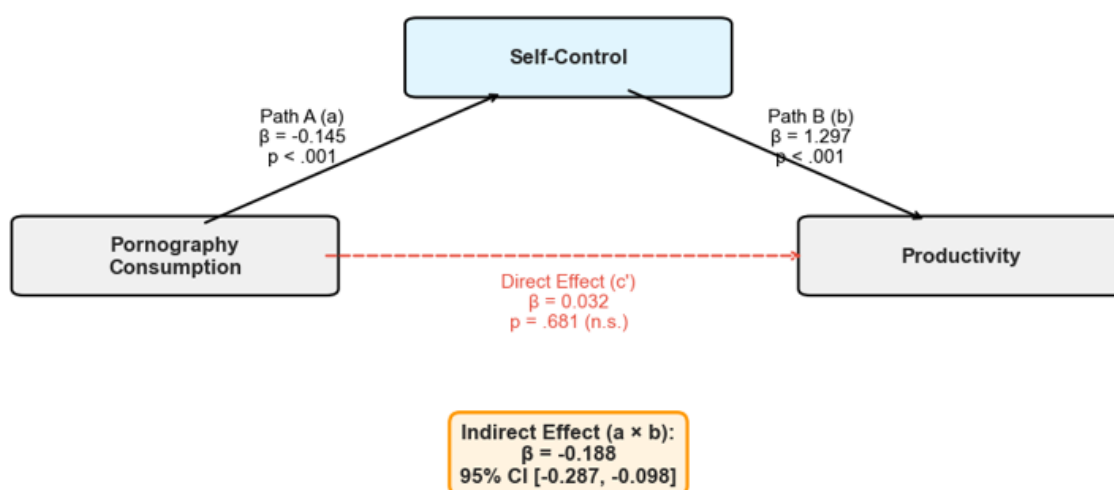


Figure 2. Mediation model

### 3. Early exposure matters.

Individuals first exposed to pornography before age 18 (74.0% of the sample) reported significantly lower self-control and productivity in adulthood. One-way ANOVA revealed significant differences across exposure groups for both self-control ( $F(4, 218) = 4.12$ ,  $p = 0.003$ ) and productivity ( $F(4, 218) = 3.23$ ,  $p = 0.013$ ). Post-hoc Tukey HSD tests identified the most vulnerable group as those first exposed between 11 and 17 years old, who showed significantly lower self-control than those first exposed at 18–21 years (11–13 vs. 18–21: mean difference = 0.53,  $p = 0.003$ ; 14–17 vs. 18–21: mean difference = 0.48,  $p = 0.014$ ). Notably, age of first exposure did not significantly predict current pornography consumption

( $F(4, 214) = 1.52, p = 0.198$ ). The majority of first exposures were not actively sought, accidental online discovery was the most common pathway (27.2%,  $n = 68$ ).

#### 4. Men consume more, but outcomes are similar across genders.

Males reported significantly higher pornography consumption than females (Male  $M = 2.04$ ,  $SD = 1.70$  vs. Female  $M = 0.85$ ,  $SD = 1.00$ ; Mann-Whitney  $U = 4512.50, p < 0.001$ , effect size = 0.41). However, there were no significant gender differences in self-control (Male  $M = 3.05$ ,  $SD = 0.77$  vs. Female  $M = 3.12$ ,  $SD = 0.75$ ; Welch's  $t = 0.70, p = 0.485$ ) or productivity (Male  $M = 6.28$ ,  $SD = 1.93$  vs. Female  $M = 5.94$ ,  $SD = 1.91$ ; Welch's  $t = -1.40, p = 0.162$ ). This challenges the assumption that pornography related effects are male specific. The mediation mechanism appears to operate similarly for both genders.

### Key Findings: Non-Technical Summary

| Objective                                                             | Conclusion                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Is pornography consumption linked to productivity?                 | Yes.<br>People who watch more pornography tend to be less productive. Although the effect size in this sample was small suggesting that pornography is only one of many factors. |
| 2. Does self-control mediate the relationship (explain this link)?    | Yes<br>Pornography does not directly reduce productivity. Instead, it weakens self-control, and weakened self-control reduces productivity.                                      |
| 3A. Does early exposure affect self-control?                          | Yes.<br>People first exposed at a younger age had lower self-control as adults.                                                                                                  |
| 3B. Does early exposure affect productivity?                          | Yes.<br>People first exposed at a younger age were less productive as adults.                                                                                                    |
| 3C. Does early exposure affect how much someone consumes as an adult? | No.<br>Early exposure did not significantly predict adult consumption.                                                                                                           |
| 4A. Do men and women differ in Porn consumption?                      | Yes.<br>Men consume significantly more pornography than women.                                                                                                                   |
| 4B. Do men and women differ in self-control?                          | No.<br>Men and women reported similar levels of self-control.                                                                                                                    |
| 4C. Do men and women differ in productivity?                          | No.<br>Men and women reported similar productivity.                                                                                                                              |

## Where to Explore Further

| Resource                     | Description                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Full Report</b>           | Complete analysis with methodology, all statistical tests, and full discussion.<br><br><a href="https://github.com/chuks007-data/pornography-self-control-productivity-study">https://github.com/chuks007-data/pornography-self-control-productivity-study</a> |
| <b>Interactive Dashboard</b> | Visual exploration of the findings via Power BI.                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Contact</b>               | Chukwuka Odey   <a href="https://www.linkedin.com/in/chukwuka-odey/">linkedin.com/in/chukwuka-odey/</a><br>chukwukaodey@gmail.com                                                                                                                              |

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**Thank you for your interest in this research.**